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Council For Burley Tobacco

FOR YOUR INFORMATION

UK flareup leaves the tobacco research institute under a cloud

THE CHARGES and countercharges flying around the University of Kentucky's Tobacco Research and Health Institute and its suspended director, Gary L. Huber, may have to be settled by a court as well as by the university. But UK already stands convicted of poor judgment in hiring Dr. Huber in the first place. The institute itself suffers from guilt by association.

Even before the current allegations of erratic management of the research program, abuse of employees, fabrication of research data and financial irregularities,

Dr. Huber had been an outspoken defender of the tobacco industry's position on tobacco and health. He acknowledges that he has personal and financial ties to the tobacco industry.

Dr. Huber, of course, is entitled to his opinions, however little support they may have in the medical and scientific community. But the first promise made when the institute was founded 11 years ago was that the research agency would be strictly scientific, avoiding any role as an apologist for the tobacco industry.

Making that promise credible was

tough task at best, since the institute wouldn't have been founded except for the importance of tobacco to Kentucky's economy. And, by law, its board of directors is made up largely of tobacco industry representatives.

Nevertheless, many leaders in establishing the institute recognized clearly enough that a public research agency with a reputation for bias would be worth less than nothing — and a dis-

credit to the sponsoring university. They acted accordingly in choosing personnel, produced a case of indigestion that may, until recently, the Tobacco and be hard to cure. y

Health Research Institute has had an excellent scientific reputation.

But temptation overwhelmed the board when it came time to replace the late Dr. John Wyatt as director of the institute. Here was Dr. Huber, with good academic credentials as a member of the Harvard University medical faculty, and

claiming that "tobacco smoke isn't harmful to the vast majority of people who smoke." It must have sounded like manna from Heaven. But the "manna" has produced a case of indigestion that may, until recently, the Tobacco and be hard to cure. y

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